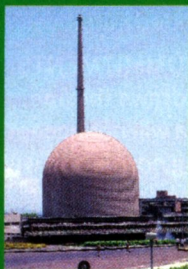


What We Should Do Pronto

SOLAR LANTERNS With 400 mn households without electricity, cheap solar lanterns could revolutionise rural lighting and also ease the pressure of producing power from coal-based plants. A national plan to popularise solar lamps needs to be launched.

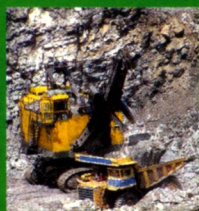


SOLAR POWER India has just announced an ambitious plan to install 20,000 MW of solar power by 2020. It needs to find both the money and technology to execute it fast.



NUCLEAR ENERGY The Indo-US nuclear deal has opened the doors to both technology and fuel to add another 30,000 MW of nuclear power by 2020. These projects need to be put on the fast track and construction of fast-breeder projects speeded up.

CLEAN COAL India's coal-based plants need to adopt clean-coal technology to improve efficiency and also reduce emissions. Also needed is the technology for carbon capture and sequestration.



ENERGY EFFICIENCY The new green building codes as well as the norms for electrical appliances and fuel-efficient cars need to be imposed strictly. The penalty for non-compliance must be increased. Incentives could be given to those using green tech.

MASS TRANSPORTATION The urban transport sector accounts for a major chunk of India's GHG emissions. The only way out is to provide mass transportation alternatives like the Metro and dissuade people from using cars and scooters to commute to work.



that Ramesh was only expressing his personal views. Ramesh had clearly jumped the gun without making the requisite political preparations for India's nuanced proactive approach or carrying the country's official negotiators along. That he corrected by shooting off letters to all MPs and explaining India's position.

His actions were vindicated when China announced a 40 per cent cut in its emission intensity. Earlier Brazil and Indonesia, two large developing countries, also announced voluntary emission cuts. China took on a leadership role by inviting India, Brazil and South Africa to form a block called BASIC and come out with a joint proposal for Copenhagen that pushed for enhanced commitments for developed countries.

Ramesh then moved swiftly to regain the initiative. In the Lok Sabha, speaking extempore, he raised the level of debate with his erudite exposition and announced that India would consider carbon emission intensity cuts of between 20 and 25 per cent by 2020. This would be the first time that India was committing to voluntary cuts. The confidence came because with the help of Montek Singh Ahluwalia, deputy chairman of the Planning Commission, he was able to get the commission to endorse the feasibility of such cuts. These are far milder than the carbon emission cuts that industrialised countries have been asked to do. Ramesh drew clear red lines that India would not agree to legally binding emission cuts or any peaking of its emission levels. As a concession, he added that on India's NAMO proposals, it was not averse to opening it up for international consultation or scrutiny. That created an uproar with BJP MP Arun Jaitley saying, "The announcement of unilateral cuts has weakened India's negotiating position". Two Indian negotiators, Dasgupta and Proditpo Ghosh, a former environment secretary, threatened to pull out. They relented only when Ramesh assured them that India's stand on per capita emissions would not be diluted and only NAMO plans that were financed internationally would be open for scrutiny.

The immediate impact of India and China's announcements saw US President Barack Obama announcing that he would attend the summit on December 18 instead of the 9th, signalling a shift in the American position and possibly a new deal at Copenhagen. Despite the criticism, Ramesh has clearly bought for India negotiating space and taken away any impression that it was "going to be a deal breaker". But, India needs to look beyond Copenhagen. China already has. For its own future India needs to move swiftly on the national missions that it has set for itself, apart from encouraging huge investments in green technology. It must try and emerge as a leader in clean tech and grab a share of the \$2-trillion market that it is opening up. Ramesh jokes, "India still has too many holy cows and they all emit methane." It's time he slayed more of them. ■